Education and learning

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Rethinking education: from the classroom to lifelong learning (277 words)

For most of the twentieth century, education followed a fixed route. Children attended **state schools**, where a standard **curriculum** was delivered by teachers, and success was measured by **academic achievement** in written exams. **Literacy** and numeracy were the main aims, and attendance was **compulsory** until the mid-teens. Today that picture is changing fast.

One striking trend is the rise of homeschooling and **distance learning**. Supported by digital platforms, families who feel that mainstream schools **fall short of** their expectations can now design their own programmes. Critics warn that such children miss out on **extracurricular** activities and on the social skills that develop among classmates. Supporters reply that homeschooled children escape the worst effects of **peer pressure** and the habit of **rote learning** that still dominates many classrooms. Employers increasingly ask schools to teach **critical thinking** rather than the memorization of facts.

Higher education faces different pressures. Soaring **tuition fees** mean that a degree can leave a young person in debt for decades, so many students look for a **scholarship** or choose **vocational** courses that lead more directly to a job. Some **drop out of** university altogether, and the **dropout** rate has become a recurring headline. Others **enrol** on short online courses and build a **qualification** piece by piece. A student who **graduates** today can no longer expect to stop learning: the idea of **lifelong learning** has moved from slogan to survival strategy. Meanwhile the traditional **lecture** is giving way to small discussions guided by a **mentor**, and the old model of strict **discipline** is being replaced by one based on motivation. Whether this shift **lives up to** its promises will depend on how fairly access to it is shared.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
state schools	schools paid for and run by the government
fall short of	fail to reach
drop out of	leave without finishing
lives up to	meets the level of

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
curriculum	n	the subjects taught in a school	*The curriculum should include practical life skills.*

literacy	n	the ability to read and write	*Adult literacy has risen sharply in the last decade.*
tuition fees	n	money paid for teaching at a university	*Rising tuition fees put pressure on families.*
compulsory	adj	something you must do by law	*Education is compulsory until the age of sixteen.*
vocational	adj	connected with a job or skill	*Vocational courses prepare students for real work.*
distance learning	n	studying away from a school, usually online	*Distance learning allows people to study while they work.*
academic achievement	n	success in studies	*Small classes can improve academic achievement.*
peer pressure	n	the influence of people your own age	*Peer pressure often affects teenagers' choices.*
rote learning	n	learning by repeating facts	*Rote learning does not develop critical thinking.*
critical thinking	n	judging ideas carefully	*Schools should teach critical thinking from an early age.*
dropout	n	a person who leaves education early	*The dropout rate is highest among teenage boys.*
enrol	v	to join a course officially	*She decided to enrol on an evening course.*
graduate	v	to finish a university degree	*He graduated with a degree in engineering.*
qualification	n	an exam or course you have passed	*A good qualification improves your job prospects.*
extracurricular	adj	outside the normal lessons	*Extracurricular activities build confidence.*
scholarship	n	money given to a student for study	*A scholarship made university possible for her.*
lecture	n	a long talk given to students	*Many students find lectures too passive.*
discipline	n	training that teaches control and order	*Strict discipline can reduce bullying.*
mentor	n	an experienced person who guides a younger one	*A mentor helped him choose a career.*
lifelong learning	n	learning throughout your life	*Lifelong learning is essential in a changing economy.*

Practice: fill the gaps

scholarship · graduate · qualification · compulsory · vocational · literacy · distance learning · lifelong learning

1. A _____ made university possible for her.
2. He _____ with a degree in engineering.
3. A good _____ improves your job prospects.
4. Education is _____ until the age of sixteen.
5. _____ courses prepare students for real work.
6. Adult _____ has risen sharply in the last decade.
7. _____ allows people to study while they work.
8. _____ is essential in a changing economy.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

pupil (n): a child at school
undergraduate (n): a student studying for a first degree
postgraduate (n): a student studying after a first degree
faculty (n): a department or group of related subjects at a university
syllabus (n): the list of topics in a course
semester (n): half of an academic year
kindergarten (n): a school for very young children
boarding school (n): a school where students live
state school (n): a school paid for by the government
private tuition (n): extra lessons paid for by parents
mixed-ability (adj): including students of different levels
streaming (n): dividing students into groups by ability
truancy (n): staying away from school without permission
bullying (n): repeated unkind behavior toward others
dyslexia (n): a difficulty with reading and spelling
numeracy (n): the ability to work with numbers
cram (v): to study hard in a short time
revise (v): to review work before an exam
coursework (n): work done during a course, not in an exam
assessment (n): the judgment of a student's ability
tutor (n): a private teacher
pass rate (n): the percentage of students who succeed
grade inflation (n): the rise of marks without better performance
head teacher (n): the person in charge of a school
class size (n): the number of students in a class
learning outcome (n): what a student should know after a course
motivated (adj): keen to learn
hands-on (adj): practical, learning by doing
well-rounded (adj): having many skills and interests
rote (n): learning by repetition

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Some people think children should start formal education at a very early age. To what extent do you agree or disagree? (opinion)
2. Some believe university should be free for everyone; others think students should pay. Discuss both views and give your opinion. (both views)
3. More people are choosing to study online rather than in a classroom. What are the advantages and disadvantages? (advantages / disadvantages)
4. Many students leave school without useful life skills. What are the causes and what solutions can you suggest? (problem / solution)

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Online learning is flexible and cheaper, so more people can study, for example parents and workers.
- **Against / bad:** Pupils learn less social skills without classmates and may lose motivation without a teacher.
- **For / good:** Practical subjects such as finance and cooking prepare students for real life.
- **Against / bad:** Rote learning produces students who can pass exams but cannot think critically.
- **For / good:** Scholarships and free tuition widen access and reduce inequality.
- **Against / bad:** If the state pays for all degrees, taxpayers bear the cost and some courses may lose value.

Speaking

Part 1

- Do you enjoy studying? Why?
- What subject did you like most at school?
- Would you like to study abroad?
- How do you usually study for a test?
- Do you prefer studying alone or with others?

Part 3

- Should schools teach life skills as well as academic subjects?
- How is teaching different now from the past?
- Do you think university is necessary for success?
- What role should technology play in classrooms?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a teacher who influenced you. You should say: who the teacher was, what they taught, how they taught, and explain why they influenced you.

Answers

1. scholarship (scholarship)
2. graduated (graduate)
3. qualification (qualification)
4. compulsory (compulsory)
5. Vocational (vocational)
6. literacy (literacy)
7. Distance learning (distance learning)
8. Lifelong learning (lifelong learning)